

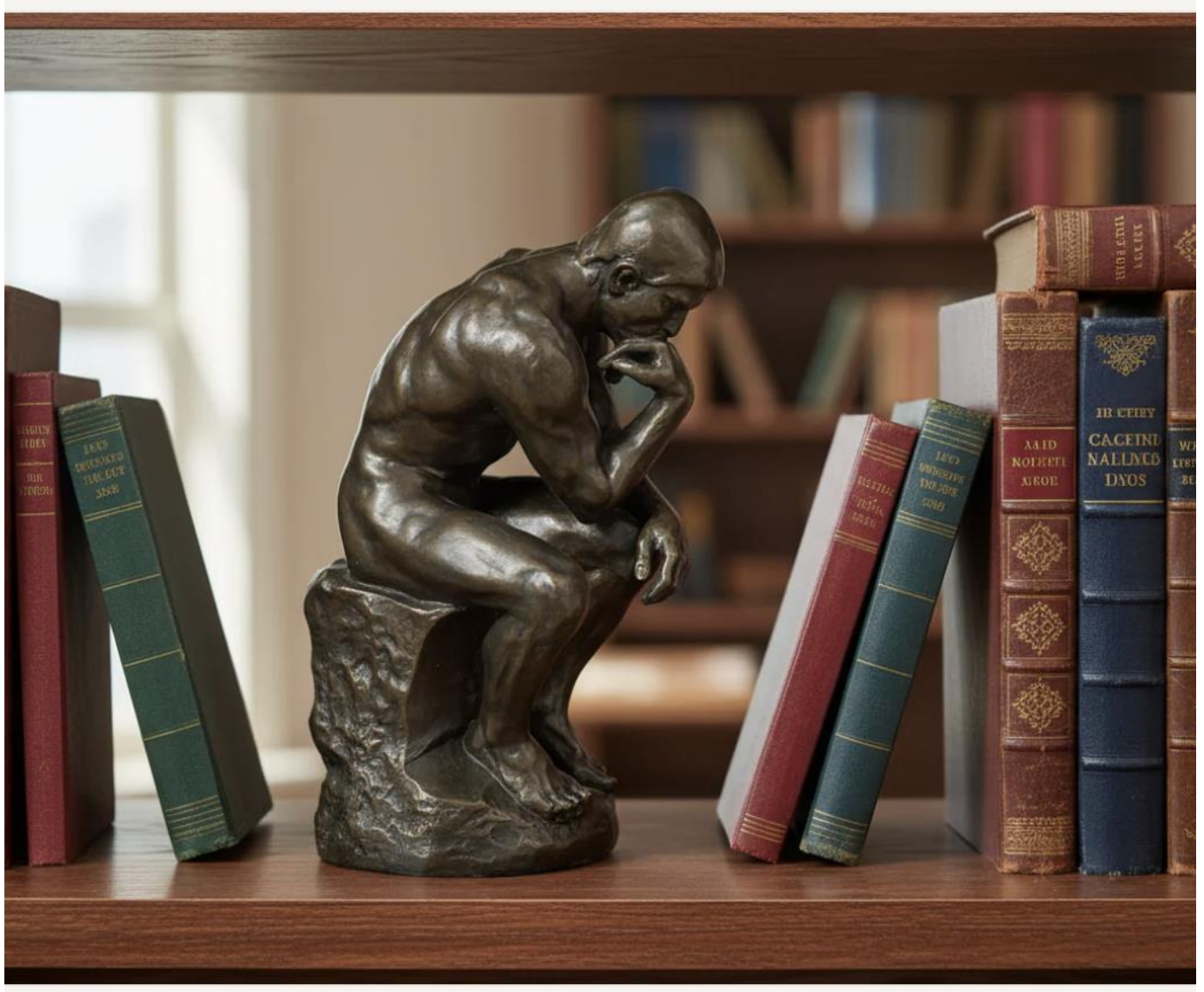
CRACKING THE CODE: LITERATURE ESSAYS

NSC USER GROUP: English

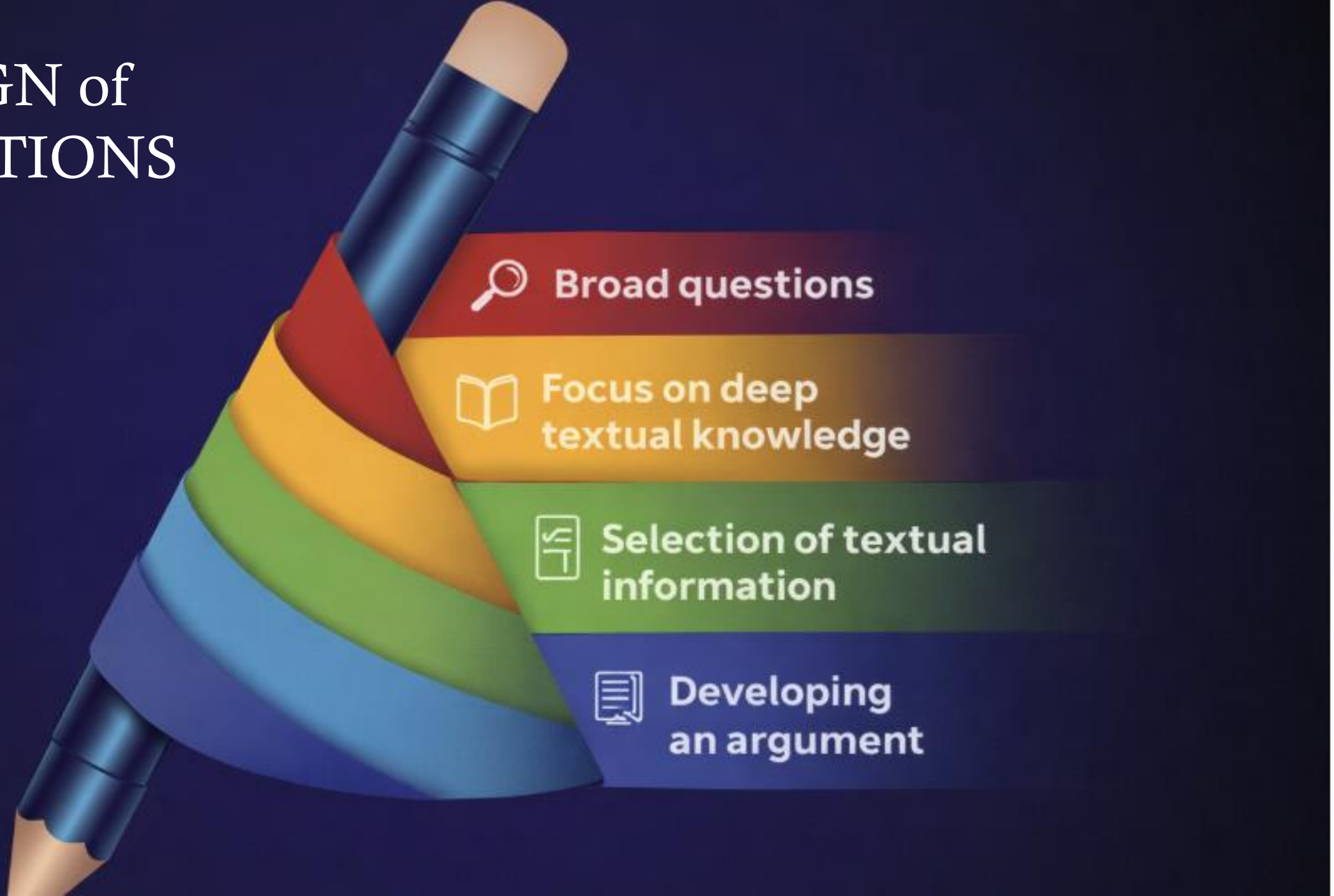
2026

A FEW POINTS TO THINK ABOUT…

- A ‘feel good’ question
- Pupils can prepare: the more they practice the better they will do
- Builds confidence
- Develops and assesses high order thinking
- Encourages voice – move beyond PEEL



DESIGN of QUESTIONS



- Listening for alternate, valid responses
- Linking back to the cognitive bands
- Developing a coherent, logical, persuasive argument linked to the question
- Ability to synthesise information and show a rich understanding of Shakespeare text and novels
- A process that needs to be scaffolded from earlier grades

TEXT IS KING



Close Textual Reading

Character Conflict Didactics

Assist executive functioning

Sources, notes, not study guides

ACADEMIC RIGOUR: A FEW REMINDERS



- Present tense
- Embedded quotations
- Formal register
- Short, accurate quotations
- No quotations in introduction or conclusion
- Generalisations from other subjects: ‘to a large extent’, ‘in conclusion’, ‘throughout the play’
- Discourage the word ‘theme’ and ‘appearance vs reality’
- Othello vs Othello
- Accurate spelling of character/place names
- Avoid rhetorical questions
- Selection from the entire text
- Paragraphs
- Plot/narration vs context
- Keep sentences short and clear- transition
- No new points in the conclusion
- No intertextuality

THE RUBRIC: NOT A TICKBOX

30 – 39%	40 – 49%	50 – 59%
• No evidence of text being reread • Faulty analysis	• Reliance on narrative • Not related to the question • Skimpy details	• Has a sense of the play but argument is broad and general • Marginally dipping into text • Argument very broad

60 – 69%

- Discusses all aspects of the question
- Does the job
- Ideas need further development
- Stance in opening

70 - 79%

- Good to very good essay
- Has strong voice
- Selection of material builds argument
- Substantiated carefully
- Clear stance in opening

80 - 89%

- Discusses all aspects of the question
- A sophisticated essay
- Shows insight and development
- Strong argument
- References used effectively to substantiate a strong argument

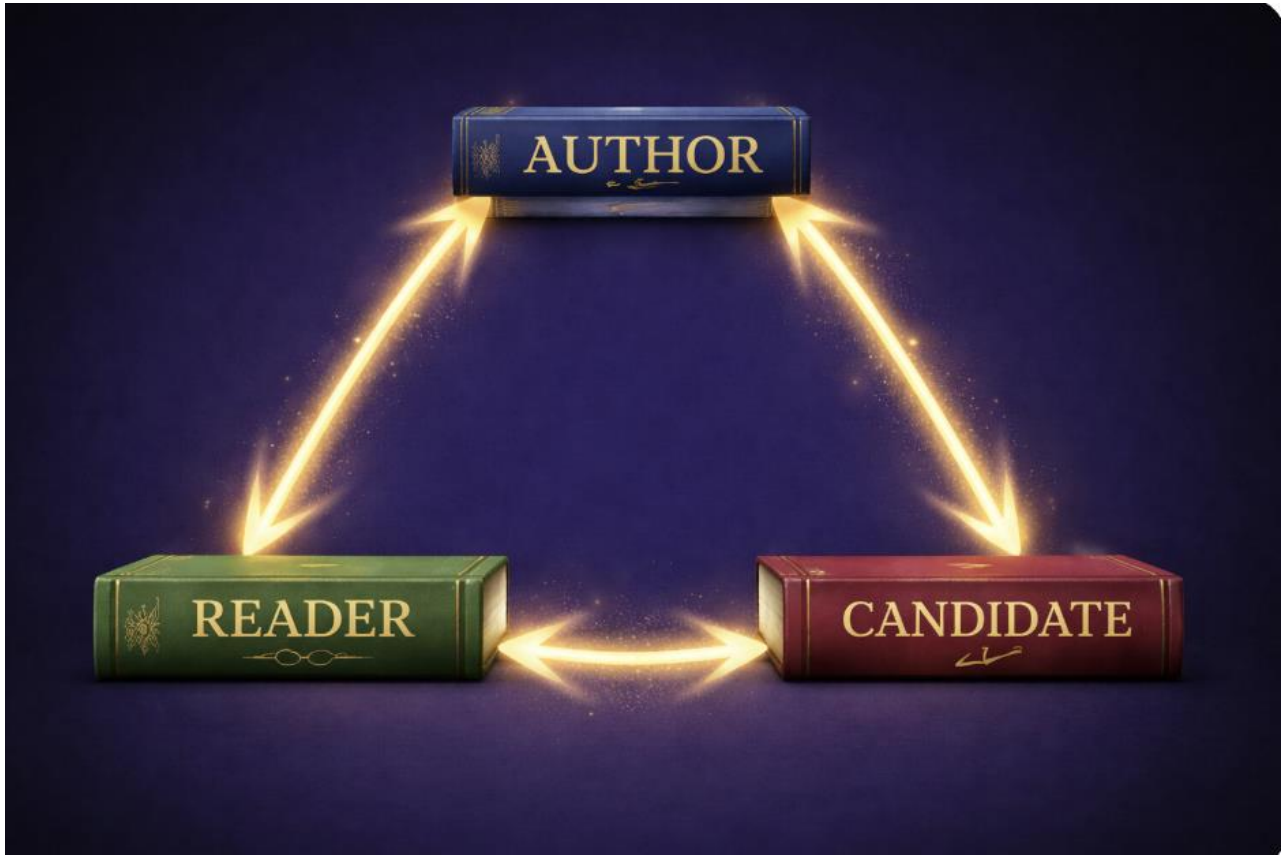
90 - 99%

- A superior essay
- Commendable argument
- Has depth and breadth of knowledge
- Substantiated with skill
- Written with refinement
- Academic Rigour

100%

- An exceptional essay
- Stands out
- Substantiated with skill
- Written with utmost refinement
- Question thoroughly tackled with insight

AUTHORIAL FIRST PERSON



- Positions candidates as the author of the essay and ideas in the essay. It amplifies voice and demonstrates personal response to the text and the nuances in the question.
- Accepted in most spheres of academic writing. Academic writing (as in literary essays) is not a disembodied practice representing a view from nowhere; instead, it is better seen as an evidence-based situated practice. All writing is done by a person, and that person necessarily writes from a particular perspective. Since the candidate is the author, the candidate needs to be positioned in the text. The authorial first person is crucial to that visibility.
- The style of writing generally improves. Creates a stance in opening and closes the argument in the conclusion.
- An integral feature of most academic writing.

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE AND ARTIFICIAL ESSAYS: BOON OR PLAGUE?



"ChatGPT provided a basic answer in each case, with **numerous inaccuracies**. Were the essay written by a student, one would infer only a **superficial understanding of the core issues**. Although the **essays were well-written**, they would **receive either a failing grade or a low passing grade** because of the lack of references or the inclusion of fabricated ones. Furthermore, ChatGPT's **inability to evaluate arguments and lack of nuanced understanding of the questions** posed made it **unsuitable for education assessments**, especially for subjects that **require critical thinking**".

THE ETHICAL USE of AI:

Prompt 1: "Please provide an essay plan for an Literary essay entitled ["insert title"]; including, but not restricted to, the following topics: "[Topic 1; Topic 2; Topic 3]".

Prompt 4: "Please provide feedback based on the rubric att on the essay entitled [insert]"

Prompt 5: "Please suggest ways in which I can improve the following section of my essay entitled [".."

https://news.uj.ac.za/news/a-practical-guide-to-ethical-use-of-chatgpt-in-essay-writing-2/

THE ESSAY TOPIC

Study the quotation below and then write a literary essay in response to the topic that follows.

'To get to objective reality, we have to reflect on perspective. Reality cannot, in principle, be seen as it is. Reality, as it is, is twisted.'

– Karsten Harries

[Adapted from: Harries, Karsten. *Infinity and Perspective*, Cambridge, Mass: MIT Press, 2001, p. 34. [<https://mitpress.mit.edu/9780262582186/infinity-and-perspective/>]]

TOPIC:

Critically discuss to what extent characters in Shakespeare's *Othello* **view reality** as **untrustworthy** and **twisted by perspective**.

You must refer to a minimum of **TWO** characters in your response.

***THE WHITE TIGER:* ARAVIND ADIGA**

Read the following:

'Literature about poverty has long been analysed for forms of prejudice – and resistance to this prejudice: the power of representation, the importance of authority, and the agency to act and speak for oneself.'

– Barbara Korte

[Adapted from: Barbara Korte. 'Can the Indigent Speak? Poverty Studies, the Postcolonial and Global Appeal of Q & A and The White Tiger.' Connotations Vol. 20.2-3: 293-312]

TOPIC:

Argue to what extent Adiga, in *The White Tiger*, portrays characters who **resist poverty** and **prejudice** in order to **act** for themselves.

You must refer to a minimum of **TWO** characters in your response.

[30]

QUESTION 2

***BRAVE NEW WORLD:* ALDOUS HUXLEY**

Read the following:

'While the writer found many aspects of his world ridiculous or horrific, he used writing as a way to work through ideas about how an improved society might function.'

– Susanna Shapland

[Adapted from: <https://communitylivingmagazine.com/brave-new-world-satire-or-blueprint/>]

TOPIC:

Critically discuss whether Huxley, in *Brave New World*, interrogates **horrific** and **ridiculous aspects of humanity** as a way of imagining an **improved society**.

You must refer to a minimum of **TWO** characters in your response.

[30]

HOW am I going to select facts and build my argument?

What do I have to show?

INTRODUCTION:

WHAT TO DO BEFORE WRITING:

- An understanding of the topic – bold words.
- Think of synonyms of bold words that will be used in the body of essay.
- 'Critically Evaluate', 'Critically Argue', 'Suggest', 'Consider', 'Argue" – What is my stance going to be? Plan HOW I am going to prove it/persuade the marker?

THE IMPORTANCE OF THE INTRODUCTION:

- Short, meaningful and precise
- First impression the marker has of the direction of your essay and the thinking behind it.
- It immediately demonstrates an understanding of the topic esp the **bold words** and how they link to the **novel/play.**
- Good academic practice to include playwright/author and title of text.
- Refer to the topic using the **bold words**. Ensure that all the **bold words** are used.
- Indicate stance: How?



THE PLATFORM PARAGRAPH

- What is it?
- Is it always essential?
- The power that it holds.
- Must give purpose to the topic. SIGNPOSTED to bold words.
- Should include short, embedded quotations that link to the topic.
- Must move seamlessly into the body.
- THINK: What value does it add to the argument?

THE BODY OF THE ESSAY

- Each paragraph builds a point that fuels the argument.
- A topic sentence; show how, show where, show why.
- Carefully selected, embedded quotations may sprinkle the paragraph provided that they are not merely embellishments.
- You may start the paragraph with a quotation if it meaningfully leads into the argument of the paragraph eg. “Valiant Othello” displays traits that are honourable.
- Link to key words of the topic. Use synonyms to prevent stilted phrasing.
- THINK: How is this paragraph building the argument that the question asks?
- Work chronologically through the text.
- The selection of information is the differentiator between a ‘good’ essay and an ‘outstanding’ essay.
- The pen-ultimate paragraph must move naturally towards conclusion



TRANSITION WORDS, PHRASES

- Although
- Considering
- Because
- If
- While
- Since
- Whether
- If we consider
- When
- However
- Indeed
- Yet
- Further

THE POWER OF VERBS

They build VOICE!	Demonstrates	Illustrates	Reveals	Signifies
Represents	Characterizes	Portrays	Symbolises	Indicates



THE CONCLUSION

- Do not start ‘In conclusion’
- The conclusion needs to draw back to the topic and the stance taken.
- End with a powerful conclusive statement that draws argument to a powerful end.
- No quotations/new points
- By the time the marker ends the essay the marker must feel:
    - The persuasive argument is thorough and in depth
    - Candidate has demonstrated an engaging and cohesive argument that is purposefully drawn from the text
    - Candidate has signposted the essay in a nuanced fashion throughout
    - Language is precise
    - Points have not been left in isolation

READ THE EXAMINER'S REPORT

ESSAY TOPIC PRACTICE

TEACH SIGNPOSTING

START EARLY

THE MORE THEY WRITE THE BETTER THEY GET